

Ethical Decision-Making Assignment

Case Study of Breanna for CE629

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Step 1: Defining the Ethical Dilemma



Defining the situation

Emotional Definition

- I feel  **empathy** and  **protectiveness** for Breanna, She was once thriving and is now suffering humiliation and isolation.
- I feel  **anger** towards her peers who exploited her trust.
- I feel  **fear** and **uncertainty** about legal implications since Breanna is a minor and this constitutes sexual exploitation material under federal law.

My emotional responses may be natural and not irrelevant, but if left unchecked, they can bias decision making. This could possibly lead to **countertransference** in the therapeutic relationship.

Objective Definition

- **Facts:**
 - Breanna (15) sent a private photo to a peer; it was distributed without consent.
 - The image was shared widely among students, possibly online.
 - She is now experiencing academic decline, withdrawal, and emotional distress.
 - No adults besides me are aware of this yet.

This dilemma involves **student confidentiality**, **sexual exploitation**, **mental health**, **cyberbullying**, and **mandatory reporting laws**.

Contextual Layers

Legal



Distribution of explicit images of a minor constitutes **child pornography** under U.S. law, even if the image was initially consensually created. (18 U.S.C. § 2252)

I am legally mandated to report under Pennsylvania's Child Protective Services Law, which identifies school employees as mandated reporters (23 Pa.C.S. § 6311).

Ethical

Breaching confidentiality could cause **retraumatization**.

I must act ethically and legally while maintaining empathy and transparency.



School Policy

Likely covered under Title IX (**sexual harassment/sexual violence**) and cyberbullying policy (20 U.S.C. § 1681).

Defining Statement:

The ethical dilemma is how to protect Breanna's safety and legal rights while maintaining her trust, honoring her cultural and developmental context, and meeting mandatory reporting obligations.



Human

A child is experiencing shame and trauma that could lead to depression and suicidal ideation.

Step 2: Identifying Cultural, Religious, and Worldview Factors



My Background



Cultural Background

I identify as a White American with European heritage, shaped by a predominantly Western, U.S. cultural upbringing. My worldview has also been influenced by academic environments, my studies in linguistics and school counseling, and diverse interpersonal and professional experiences.

Religion & Spirituality

I do not strictly identify with any organized religion, but my spirituality leans toward open-minded reflection, curiosity, and meaning-making rather than doctrine. I value introspection, personal growth, and the belief that people create meaning through relationships, creativity, and compassion.

Worldview

My worldview emphasizes empathy, respect, and understanding across cultural differences. I approach others with a belief in dignity, autonomy, and the power of connection. I am guided by values of equity, open communication, and supporting students in ways that affirm their identities and lived experiences. I also view counseling through a lens of social justice, cultural humility, and advocacy, recognizing that each student's experiences are shaped by their unique cultural, familial, and societal contexts.

Identifying Cultural Factors

Cultural Context

- Breanna identifies as a **Black American** with **Jamaican immigrant parents**.
 - Jamaican and Caribbean family cultures emphasize **family reputation** and **privacy** around topics of sexuality, seeing it as a taboo topic. (Gabbidon & Shaw-Ridley, 2018).
 - **Intersectionality**: The school culture may stereotype or label her, and she is a victim of male peers' misuse of her image. This introduces **racialized judgements** and **gendered power imbalances**.
- She lives in a **matriarchal, multigenerational household**.
 - Her mom and grandmother may have strong moral expectations.
 - Cultural/generational gaps can complicate the conversation about sexuality, digital behavior, or victimization.



Institutional and Community Factors

- **School Climate and Power**
 - The boys' soccer team is involved, possibly a socially powerful group.
- How does the school handle **race, gender, and sexuality** in disciplinary issues?
 - Is there precedent for **victim-blaming** or disproportionate punishment?
- Community attitudes toward **sexuality and social media** may be conservative; thus, Breanna could face further isolation.



My Approach

My Cultural Self-Awareness

Asking Myself (self-interrogation):



Do I carry assumptions about sexuality, responsibility, or victimhood that might bias how I view Breanna's role?

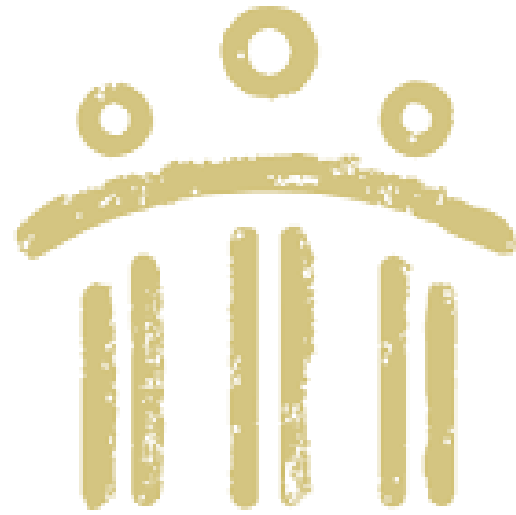
How do my values around digital behavior or modesty influence my empathy and language?



Ethical Lens

Being culturally aware will help me:

- Frame my **communication plan** with Breanna and her family in a way that is culturally humble and empowering, not authoritative or shaming.
- Ensure **equity and justice** are central to my ethical decision.
- Recognize how **power, privilege and culture** intersect to impact the harm and helping process.



AMERICAN
SCHOOL
COUNSELOR
ASSOCIATION

Step 3:

Applying the *ASCA Ethical Standards for School Counselors*, state laws, and the relevant district policies and procedures.

ASCA Ethical Standards (2022)

According to the *ASCA Ethical Standards for School Counselors* (American School Counselor Association [ASCA], 2022), school counselors should...



A.2 - Confidentiality

“... Keep information confidential unless legal requirements demand confidential information be revealed or a breach is required to prevent serious and foreseeable harm to the student or others” (Section f).

How it applies here:

Breanna disclosed a traumatic sexual incident.
A school counselor must balance privacy with mandated reporting, Title IX requirements, and safety.

A.9 - Serious and Foreseeable Harm to Self and Others

“... Inform parents/guardians and school administration when a student poses a serious and foreseeable risk of harm to self or others” (Section a).

How it applies here:

- The non-consensual distribution of her nude image is ongoing harm.
- She’s withdrawing, declining academically, and at risk of depression.
- A school counselor is ethically obligated to involve guardians, administration, and likely law enforcement.

A.11 - Bullying, Harassment, Discrimination, Bias, and Hate Incidents

“...Recognize that bullying, discrimination, bias and hate incidents rooted in race, gender, sexual orientation and ethnicity are violations of federal law and many state and local laws and district policies” (Section a).

How it applies here:

Breanna experienced gender-based bullying and sexual harassment when her nude image was shared without consent, which violates federal law and district policy. A school counselor is required to report this behavior to administration/Title IX and ensure Breanna receives protection, support, and a response free from bias.



ASCA Ethical Standards (2022)(Continued)

According to the *ASCA Ethical Standards for School Counselors* (American School Counselor Association [ASCA], 2022), school counselors should...



A.15 - Technical and Digital Citizenship

“...Promote the safe and responsible use of technology in collaboration with educators and families” (Section d).”

How it applies here:

Breanna’s case involves the unsafe and inappropriate use of digital media, which directly triggers the counselor’s role in promoting responsible technology use.

B.1 – Responsibilities to Parents/Guardians

“... Provide parents/guardians with accurate, comprehensive and relevant information in a caring manner as appropriate and consistent with legal and ethical responsibilities to the students and parents/guardians” (Section j).

How it applies here:

The counselor must inform Breanna’s parent/guardian about the situation in a caring and appropriate way due to the serious harm involved. B.1 ensures the disclosure is accurate, relevant, and sensitive to Breanna’s emotional needs.



Pennsylvania State Law

PA Child Protective Services Law (CPSL) (23 Pa.C.S. § 6303 and § 6311)

- Under CPSL, school counselors are mandated reporters and must report suspected child abuse, including sexual abuse or exploitation (23 Pa.C.S. § 6303; § 6311).
- However, peer-to-peer sexual misconduct is not always reportable to ChildLine unless the perpetrator meets CPSL's legal definition of a "perpetrator" (e.g., parent, caregiver, household member, or someone responsible for the child's welfare) (23 Pa.C.S. § 6303).

Pennsylvania Sexting Statute (Transmission of Sexually Explicit Images by a Minor) (18 Pa.C.S. § 6321)

- Pennsylvania law criminalizes the transmission of sexually explicit images by minors (18 Pa.C.S. § 6321).

Mandated Reporting Training (Act 126) (24 P.S. § 12-1205-6)

- Mandatory reporting training requirements under Act 126 help guide school personnel in identifying and responding to child abuse (24 P.S. § 12-1205.6).

Cyber Harassment of a Child (18 Pa.C.S. § 2709(a.1))

- Sharing humiliating or sexual images of a minor online can constitute cyber harassment of a child. Under Pennsylvania's cyber harassment statute, it is a crime to electronically intimidate, harass, or cause emotional distress to a minor (18 Pa.C.S. § 2709(a.1)).



Step 4: Consulting with appropriate professionals

CENSORED

C1's Responses

“Have you ever encountered a similar situation, and if so, what did you do?”

+

“How would you proceed in this situation with the information provided?”

Yes, share with the student that you feel gratitude for the willingness to disclose that information with the school counselor. Be honest that you must share this. Talk about regret and how we can't go backwards, but how can we work together to resolve this and help her get back on track.

- a) Report it, do NOT look at the photo.
- b) Have her write a statement that collects information of who has the photo. (Gather information of their age)
- c) Turn it over to the administrator to work with local law enforcement
- d) Ask, “Would you like to be a part of the conversation with mom?”
 - If no, keep her in the lobby or office vicinity and wait until the parent conversation.
- e) Reassure that mom may be acting emotionally at first but may not know how to process it.
- f) Coach the parent (Frame the convo as: to be proud that your child came forward to talk about this, she's emotionally strong)
- g) Ask for the support system
- h) Mental health check-ins on how to bounce back
- i) Get an understanding of how mom wants to proceed.
- j) If in doubt, Child-line as a safety net

“Do you have any information in your student handbook or school protocols that would be relevant to this scenario?”

They would be more general in nature, this is not a school issue, it is a community issue that is why it is referred to local law enforcement. Only use the code of conduct when it impacts the learning environment (which it does) (i.e. harassment).



C2's Responses

“Have ever encountered a similar situation, and if so, what did you do?”

+

“How would you proceed in this situation with the information provided?”

Vicky shared that she *has encountered several situations involving the non-consensual sharing of intimate images*. In her past cases, she immediately involved the School Resource Officer (SRO) because the behavior constituted a potential legal violation and safety concern. Parents were required to come to the school, and in one case the student who sent the image, and the boyfriend involved, both faced police consequences.

She emphasized the importance of coordinating with law enforcement, administration, parents, and all students involved to ensure safety, clarify legal implications, and determine appropriate next steps. Her typical procedure includes meeting jointly and individually with students and parents, establishing expectations, providing support, and addressing any ongoing risks or retaliation.



“Do you have any information in your student handbook or school protocols that would be relevant to this scenario?”

Vicky stated that relevant information probably exists in the district’s student handbook, though she was unsure of the exact location. She believed it would fall under the bullying and harassment section, which typically outlines expectations regarding technology use, cyberbullying, and inappropriate sharing of digital content.

Her response highlights a common issue in school systems: staff know protocols exist but may not be fully familiar with the exact procedures, which can create inconsistency when cases arise. This suggests a potential need for clearer staff training, easier access to digital misconduct policies, and routine review of Title IX and cyberbullying procedures.



Moving Forward with the Information Provided

Post-consultation

C1 emphasized immediate reporting, protecting evidence, and involving administration/law enforcement, reflecting strong procedural alignment. She also incorporates student autonomy and parent coaching, showing trauma-informed awareness. Her framing of the incident as a “community issue” highlights role boundaries and systemic gaps.

Her approach underscores the need for clear reporting steps and careful parent communication while ensuring Breanna receives ongoing counseling and academic/safety support. Schools must avoid assuming police involvement replaces their Title IX or student-support responsibilities.



C2’s responses reinforced the seriousness of image-based sexual harassment and the need for a coordinated, multidisciplinary response. She also showed a gap in staff clarity around handbook policies, suggesting an opportunity for improved training and consistency. Her approach highlights the importance of multidisciplinary collaboration (administration, SRO, parents) but also shows how quickly cases can become punitive if not handled with developmental and trauma-informed nuance.

Her perspective reinforces the need for clear policy knowledge, strong documentation, and coordinated reporting while ensuring that Breanna’s emotional safety is prioritized. It also highlights why the counselor must maintain a balanced, trauma-informed approach so the case is not handled solely through a disciplinary or legal lens, which could worsen harm for the victim.



Step 5: Considering the Chronological & Developmental Levels

Breanna's Development

Amygdala Decision-Making

- At 15, Breanna is at an age when adolescents rely more on the **amygdala** in emotionally charged social situations, especially those involving peers (AACAP, n.d.).
- This contributes to impulsive digital decisions, such as trusting that a private photo would disappear on Snapchat.
- Combined with her still-developing prefrontal cortex, this makes her more vulnerable to manipulation, peer pressure, and misjudging long-term consequences (Tottenham & Galván, 2016).

Erikson's Stage of Development

- Breanna is in Erikson's developmental stage of **Identity vs. Role Confusion**, a period when adolescents are forming a stable sense of self and rely heavily on peer acceptance (Erikson, 1968).
- The non-consensual sharing of her intimate photo directly threatens this developmental task by causing shame, social withdrawal, and questioning of her identity.
- Because disruptions during this stage can lead to confusion and lowered self-worth, Breanna is especially vulnerable and requires developmentally sensitive support.

Kohlberg's Theory of Moral Development

- At age 15, Breanna is typically in the **Conventional Level**, where moral reasoning is shaped by peer approval and social expectations (Kohlberg, 1981).
- Decisions tend to focus on maintaining relationships, fitting in, and avoiding social disapproval.
- This makes her more vulnerable to trusting an older peer and less likely to foresee the moral or social consequences of sharing a private image.

Step 6:
Consider Rights of
Parents/Guardians and
Students

Balancing Parent/Guardian and Student Rights

Parent/Guardian Rights

- Under **ASCA Standard B.1**, parents/guardians have the right to receive “accurate, comprehensive and relevant information” when their child faces serious or foreseeable harm (ASCA, 2022, Section B.1.j).
- Pennsylvania law designates parents as the legal decision-makers for minors and grants them the right to be informed when safety, welfare, or mental health concerns arise (23 Pa.C.S. § 6311).
- Parents also have the right to participate in safety planning, access school records covered under **FERPA**, and be informed when Title IX sexual harassment investigations involve their child.

Student Rights

- ASCA requires that students be treated with dignity and that school counselors protect their confidentiality unless disclosure is necessary to prevent serious and foreseeable harm (ASCA, 2022, Section A.2).
- Students have the right to be protected from bullying, harassment, and sexual misconduct through federal and state laws, including Title IX protections against sex-based harassment (34 C.F.R. §106.30).
- Students also hold a right to autonomy, participation, and voice in matters affecting their safety and well-being, consistent with their developmental level (Erikson, 1968).
- FERPA supports the student's right to some degree of privacy and educational dignity, even when parents are informed.

In Breanna’s case, I must inform her mother due to the seriousness of the harm and legal mandates, but I will balance this with Breanna’s right to dignity, emotional safety, and voice. I will collaborate with Breanna first to plan **how** we share the information, ensure she is not shamed or blamed, and support her throughout the disclosure so parental involvement strengthens her safety rather than causing additional distress.



Step 7a: Apply the Moral Principles

Principles

★ = Most Salient/Takes Precedence

- **Autonomy**

- **Definition:** Respecting the student's right to have a voice in decisions.
- **Application:** I involve Breanna in how we disclose the incident while still ensuring required reporting.

- **Beneficence** ★

- **Definition:** Acting in the student's best interest.
- **Application:** I work to protect Breanna and connect her with supports that promote her well-being.
- **Takes precedence because...** Breanna is experiencing significant emotional and social harm, and I must act in her best interest by ensuring protection, support, and appropriate intervention.

- **Nonmaleficence** ★

- **Definition:** Avoiding actions that could cause harm.
- **Application:** I communicate sensitively and ensure the school's response does not shame or retraumatize Breanna.
- **Takes precedence because...** I must avoid actions that could retraumatize Breanna, such as insensitive communication, victim-blaming, or exposing her further during reporting.

- **Justice**

- **Definition:** Treating students fairly and equitably.
- **Application:** I advocate for a Title IX response that protects Breanna without bias and holds peers accountable.

- **Fidelity**

- **Definition:** Maintaining trust and loyalty in the counseling relationship.
- **Application:** I explain limits of confidentiality honestly and remain a consistent, supportive presence.

- **Veracity** ★

- **Definition:** Being truthful and transparent.
- **Application:** I clearly tell Breanna why reporting is required and what steps will follow.
- **Takes precedence because...** Breanna needs clear, honest information about the limits of confidentiality and what will happen next; transparency reduces fear and preserves trust during a difficult process.

Step 7b: Review the Professional Literature



Key Findings in Professional Literature

- **Non-consensual image sharing = image-based sexual abuse**, a form of online sexual exploitation with significant mental-health impact (Milne et al., 2025; Murray et al., 2020).
- **Snapchat's design creates a false sense of safety**—teens believe images disappear, but screenshots and redistribution are common (Mittmann et al., 2021).
- **Teens want balanced, non-shaming sexting education**, emphasizing consent, autonomy, and digital rights rather than fear-based messaging (Woodley et al., 2024).
- **Parents often interpret sexting through moral or risk frames**, influencing whether teens feel safe disclosing harm (Lamprianidou et al., 2025).
- **Afro-Caribbean families may view sex as taboo or shameful**, which can reduce communication and increase fear around disclosure (Gabbidon & Shaw-Ridley, 2019).
- **Youth engage in digital intimacy for connection**, but gendered double standards and peer pressure increase risk for girls experiencing non-consensual distribution (Milne et al., 2025).

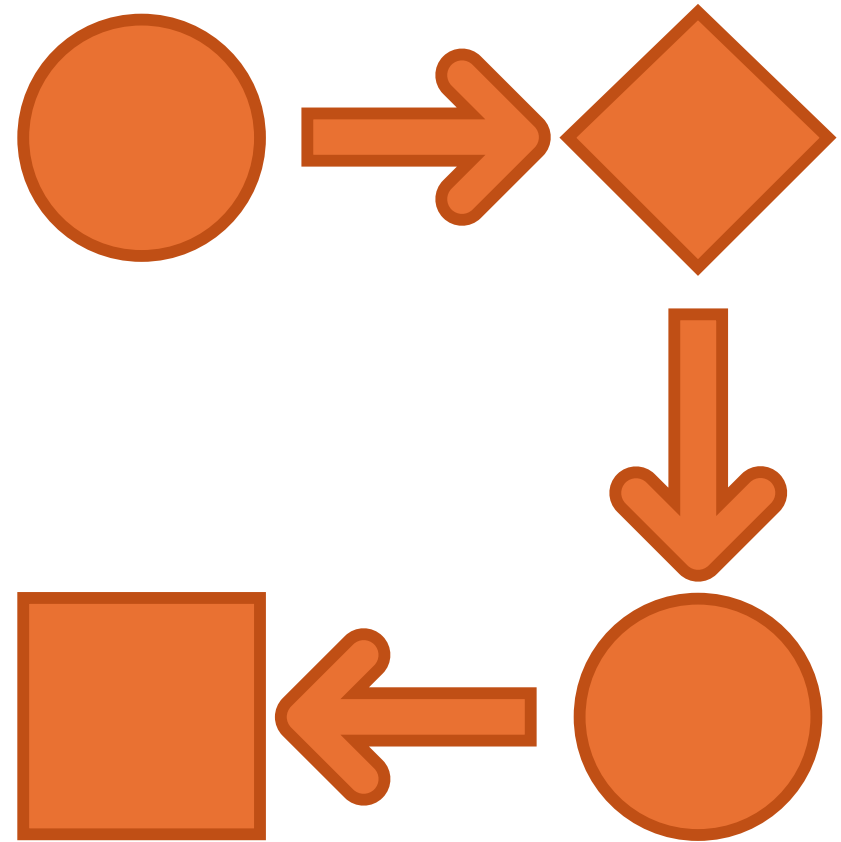
Synthesis

Recent research shows that adolescents' digital intimacy occurs within platforms like Snapchat that create “a *false sense of ephemerality*,” making teens believe images disappear even though screenshots and redistribution are common (Mittmann et al., 2021; Milne et al., 2025). When images are shared without consent, scholars identify this as image-based sexual abuse and a form of online sexual exploitation with significant emotional and developmental impacts (Milne et al., 2025; Murray et al., 2020). Studies repeatedly highlight that punitive or shame-based responses to sexting, especially toward girls, intensify trauma and discourage disclosure, whereas balanced, rights-based education emphasizing consent, digital safety, and autonomy leads to healthier coping and prevention (Woodley et al., 2024; Lamprianidou et al., 2025). Cultural research further shows that in Afro-Caribbean families, sexual topics are often treated as taboo, which may heighten adolescents' fears of judgment, reduce communication, and increase secrecy around sexual harm (Gabbidon & Shaw-Ridley, 2019).

How This Informs My Ethical Response to Breanna

- Frame Breanna’s experience as sexual harassment and image-based sexual abuse, not a “mistake,” aligning with current research and avoiding victim-blaming.
- Provide trauma-informed counseling, recognizing the serious emotional impact of non-consensual redistribution (Murray et al., 2020).
- Address the false sense of Snapchat ephemerality by educating Breanna and caregivers about digital permanence and safety tools (Mittmann et al., 2021).
- Use a balanced, non-shaming tone that validates normal adolescent exploration while emphasizing consent and harm (Woodley et al., 2024).
- Prepare for cultural sensitivity with her Jamaican/Caribbean family: anticipate shame and focus the conversation on victimization and safety rather than morality (Gabbidon & Shaw-Ridley, 2019).
- Advocate for school action under Title IX and district policy, ensuring accountability and equitable protection for Breanna.

Step 8: Potential Courses of Action & Consequences



Course of Action #1: Collaborative Reporting & Trauma-Informed Support

Course of Action	Consequences	Justice, Publicity, & Universality
Overview: A trauma-informed, student-centered approach that balances required reporting with emotional safety, transparency, and empowerment. Steps Reporting, Safety, Legal/Procedural • Explain limits of confidentiality and collaborate with Breanna to plan how (not <i>whether</i>) information will be shared with her mother/guardian. • Notify administration and Title IX coordinator about the sexual harassment and image sharing. • Administration determines whether to involve law enforcement; counselor provides context. • Coordinate with administration to implement school safety measures: monitoring hallways, preventing retaliation, and identifying safe peer/staff supports. Social/Emotional Support • Begin ongoing counseling to address trauma symptoms, shame, and identity concerns. • Teach coping skills (CBT reframing, grounding, distress tolerance). • Facilitate reconnecting with trusted peers or extracurriculars to rebuild confidence. • Offer referrals for outpatient therapy if symptoms are severe. Academic Support • Notify teachers discreetly about needed flexibility (late work, extensions). • Create a short-term academic recovery plan to rebuild confidence and reduce overwhelm. Family Support • Meet with Breanna and her mother together to discuss what happened, needs, and next steps while protecting Breanna from shame. • Educate parent on trauma responses and how to support her emotionally.	Positive • Maintains student trust while meeting legal/ethical duties. • Parent becomes a strong support system. • School takes protective action quickly. • Breanna regains stability academically and emotionally. • Reduces long-term trauma through early intervention. Negative • Breanna may initially feel exposed or betrayed by mandatory reporting. • Parent/guardian may react with anger or cultural shame. • Peers may retaliate, requiring further interventions.	Justice: Fair and equitable. This approach protects Breanna, holds perpetrators accountable, and aligns with Title IX + district policy. Publicity: Would withstand public scrutiny. These actions are transparent, legally sound, ethically grounded. Universality: Could be applied consistently to any student experiencing image-based sexual harassment.

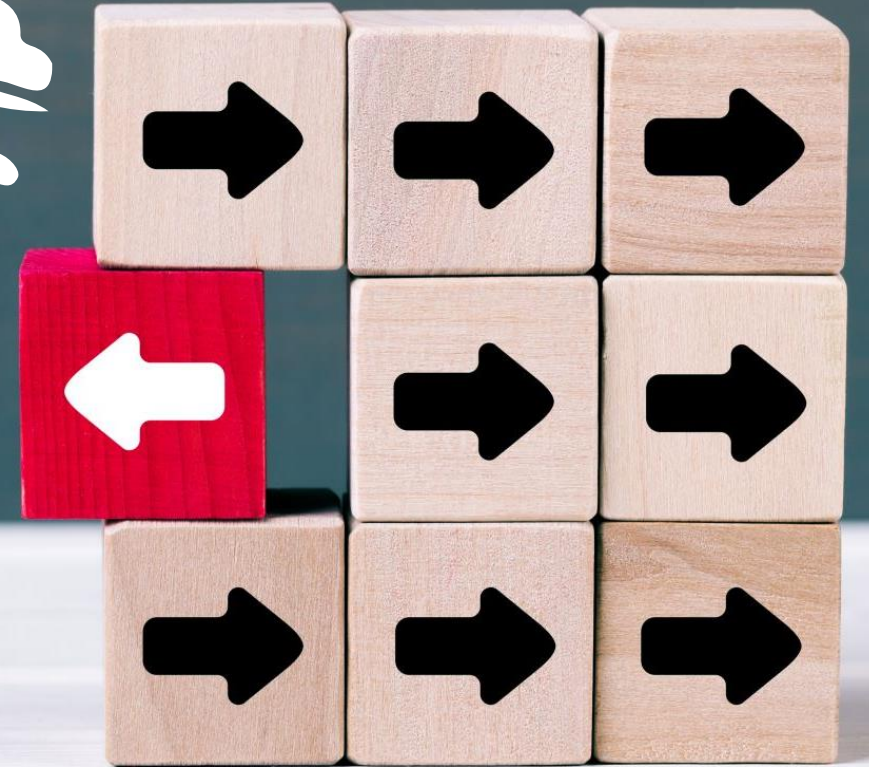
Course of Action #2: Immediate Administrative & Legal Action With Reduced Student Collaboration

Course of Action	Consequences	Justice, Publicity, & Universality
Overview: A counselor-centered, protective approach prioritizing legal compliance and rapid intervention over student involvement. Steps Reporting, Safety, Legal/Procedural • Inform administration and Title IX immediately before involving Breanna in telling her parent. • Administration contacts police and begins formal Title IX investigation. • Enact strict no-contact orders between Breanna and perpetrators. • School may place perpetrators on temporary removal from extracurriculars or school. Social/Emotional Support • Inform Breanna after decisions are already in motion; provide crisis counseling and support. • Offer short-term individual counseling and safety planning. Academic Support • Implement immediate academic adjustments, such as a reduced workload for Breanna. • Explore temporary schedule changes for emotional safety. Family Support • Contact her parent promptly after reporting; counselor later facilitates a restorative discussion.	Positive • Ensures rapid legal compliance and strong immediate protection. • Reduces risk of further harm by swiftly involving authorities. • Sends clear zero-tolerance message to school community. Negative • Breanna may feel blindsided, powerless, or betrayed. • Relationship with counselor may weaken. • Parent may feel shocked or unprepared. • Emotional distress may increase because she had no input in disclosure timing.	Justice: Protects rights but limits Breanna’s autonomy, though it is legally justified. Publicity: Publicly defensible because it follows law but may be criticized for lack of student empowerment. Universality: Could be applied to all cases but may not always be developmentally sensitive.

Course of Action #3: High-Autonomy, Student-Led Disclosure with Gradual Reporting

Course of Action	Consequences	Justice, Publicity, & Universality
Overview: A student-centered approach giving Breanna more voice and time before reporting, but still completing all required steps (Note: this is ethically risky but important to analyze for completeness.) Steps Reporting, Safety, Legal/Procedural • Spend more time building rapport and preparing Breanna emotionally before reporting. • Allow Breanna to choose whether she wants to be present during the phone call to her parent or wants the counselor to speak first. • Inform administration after parental notification; Title IX process follows. Social/Emotional Support • Engage in weekly counseling to address shame, trauma, and social withdrawal. • Encourage her to identify safe peers, trusted adults, and coping strategies. • Explore her fear of retaliation and empower her voice. Academic Support • Plan together how to communicate with teachers to request extensions or support. • Gradually rebuild her academic confidence through structured goals. Family Support • Provide psychoeducation and cultural sensitivity in family discussions to reduce stigma. • Encourage parent and student joint conversations about digital safety.	Positive • Strong preservation of trust and counselor-student relationship. • Breanna feels empowered and respected. • Reduced immediate emotional shock. Negative • Delays could risk continued harm or retaliation from peers. • Could conflict with mandatory reporting timelines. • Parent may feel frustrated for not being informed sooner. • Administration may view delayed reporting as improper.	Justice: Supports student autonomy but risks inequitable protection if delays occur. Publicity: Harder to publicly defend—may appear the counselor put rapport over safety. Universality: Not consistently applicable; delays could endanger students in similar cases.

Step 9: Carry Out Course of Action & Evaluate Outcomes



Course of Action	Rationale	Potential Outcomes
I have selected Course of Action #1: Collaborative Reporting & Trauma-Informed Support. By doing this course of action, I will: 1. Explain confidentiality limits and collaboratively plan how to inform her parent/guardian. 2. Report to administration/Title IX and follow district policy regarding sexual harassment and non-consensual image distribution. 3. Develop a safety plan, including preventing retaliation, monitoring peer behavior, and adjusting school routines if needed. 4. Provide ongoing counseling focused on trauma, shame reduction, coping skills, and rebuilding peer/academic functioning. 5. Coordinate academic supports (extensions, reduced workload, check-ins with teachers). 6. Engage parent/guardian in a supportive meeting emphasizing victimization, safety, and emotional needs.	This course of action was the most balanced route to take. Not only does it meet all legal and ethical requirements (ASCA A.2, A.9, A.11; 23 Pa.C.S. § 6311; Title IX), it also preserves trust and emotional safety. Collaborative disclosure allows Breanna to retain a sense of autonomy and reduces feelings of betrayal, which is especially important given the sensitivity of the situation. The trauma-informed support and safety planning to be utilized in this approach directly address the significant psychological, social, and academic impacts identified in the research on image-based sexual abuse. It is developmentally appropriate, prioritizing both immediate protection and long-term recovery, and it intentionally avoids punitive or shame-based responses, which research shows can worsen trauma for adolescents, particularly girls and culturally marginalized students.	<u>Positive Outcomes</u> • Breanna feels supported, validated, and protected—strengthening her trust in the counselor. • Parent/guardian becomes an ally in her emotional and academic recovery. • School administration implements protective measures that reduce ongoing harm and uphold Title IX obligations. • Breanna experiences improved emotional stability, safer peer interactions, and recovery of academic functioning. • The approach meets ethical best practices for justice, nonmaleficence, and beneficence. <u>Negative Outcomes</u> • Breanna may initially feel anxious or embarrassed about involving her parent. • Parent/guardian may react with cultural or moral concerns before understanding the harm. • Peer retaliation may temporarily increase, requiring additional safety interventions. • The reporting process may feel overwhelming for Breanna despite supportive counseling.

Step 10: Inconsistencies in School Policy & Recommendations



Policies rarely address *retaliation prevention* for victims of image-based abuse.

Title IX requires retaliation protections, but district bullying/cyberbullying policies often lack explicit procedures. A student like Breanna may continue to face peer harassment even after reporting.

Lack of clear accountability for *bystanders* who redistribute images.

Many school policies discipline the original perpetrator but lack guidance for students who forward, screenshot, or share images—despite this being a major part of the harm.

Digital citizenship education is underdeveloped or inconsistently implemented.

Research emphasizes a need for balanced, rights-based sexting education, but many PA districts still rely on fear-based or abstinence-only messaging, leaving students without tools to navigate real online risks (e.g., Snapchat's false ephemerality).

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